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Javelin Program

A 12-week design thinking coaching program for IBM’s top 80 client account teams.

OUTCOMES

The program influenced 1.2B in revenue and trail blazed design thinking in the sales context and remains a template for similar efforts.

GOAL

The coaching program needed to contextualize design thinking for consultants to differentiate them throughout the sales cycle.

CLIENT AND SCOPE

The internal client was the IBM Global Markets SVP of Integrated Accounts and my role on this team lasted just under 2 years between 2017 and 2019.

ROLE

I was a service designer, facilitator, and coach working with a small design team. My biggest contribution to the project developing learning objectives, habits, and onboarding sales teams.

How might we design a better way for account sellers to differentiate IBM in the sales cycle?

IBM's adoption of design thinking reached across the company, except sales
In 2012, IBM launched an initiative to embed design and design thinking across the company. By 2017, the Design Program Office had formalized Enterprise Design Thinking and introduced it to more than 150,000 employees, except for one stalwart holdout: sales.

Client engagements demonstrated that design thinking could impact sales
Sales' lack of adoption was both troubling and ironic because it had the most to gain. Design-led engagements were more durable, more profitable, and highly rated by clients. Yet sales teams weren't equipped to deliver this, so the Design Program Office stepped in to bring design thinking to this critical audience.

The new Enterprise Design Thinking for Sellers team forms the Javelin Program
The Enterprise Design Thinking for Sellers team began with hands-on workshop facilitation, engaging sales teams directly with clients. Insights from this work led to the Javelin Program—a pilot across four Integrated Accounts focused on coaching sellers to adopt design thinking. These roughly 90 high-profile accounts represented 30% of IBM's revenue. I joined midway through the pilot, and after a successful pitch to the CMO, the program scaled globally from 4 accounts to 90.

Changing markets required sellers to adopt new, design-led ways of working
Integrated Account sellers thrived in a market of long-term contracts, waterfall delivery, and feature-driven buyers. As software shifted to service-based models, buying moved toward continuous delivery and outcomes beyond delivery. At the same time, emerging technologies expanded IBM's largest opportunities from technical implementations to enterprise-wide business transformations.

These sellers needed to rethink how they framed problems, aligned teams, shaped proposals, and structured contracts. We believed Enterprise Design Thinking could provide the methods to support this evolution.

To teach sellers design thinking, the format had to fit their working style
Making design thinking work for sellers required rethinking how the Design Program Office delivered it. Experience and research showed that sellers operate in a fast-paced, conversation-driven environment, marked by frequent interruptions, constant travel, and work that starts and stops across multiple streams. This contrasted sharply with traditional design thinking, which is optimized for artifact-driven work, deep focus, dedicated spaces, and sustained attention on a single project.

Our vision focused on four core seller jobs, enabled by Enterprise Design Thinking
The Javelin Program aimed to help IBM's top 90 sales accounts differentiate by applying Enterprise Design Thinking across the sales cycle. The program focused on enabling sellers to frame problems around user needs and outcomes, align cross-functional teams through co-creation, develop proposals grounded in real user insights, and structure contracts that supported iterative delivery and measurable user value.

The seller's 12-week Javelin Program journey

3–4 sales accounts are brought through the program as a cohort.

Selection and onboarding

Over 3–4 meetings, our team brings together a cohort. We introduce the program, design thinking and identify a client goal.

Activation workshop

Over 3 days, we develop their design thinking skills and identify new behaviors to adopt in the context of their client goal.

Remote coaching

Over 8 weeks, coaches hold weekly remote coaching sessions with the team to progress them toward their client goal and new behaviors.

Equipping for success

Over one meeting, we hold a retrospective with each team and set new goals they own moving forward.

The program's first phase was selection and onboarding

Onboarding began by pitching the program to the account's managing director, who then selected 6–7 sellers to participate.

Over three to four meetings, sellers learned the program expectations, earned an EDT Practitioner badge to gain a working understanding of design thinking, and defined a client goal.

Structure earned trust

This internal timeline shows the coordination used to prepare sellers for kickoff. The structured rollout built trust and improved adoption.

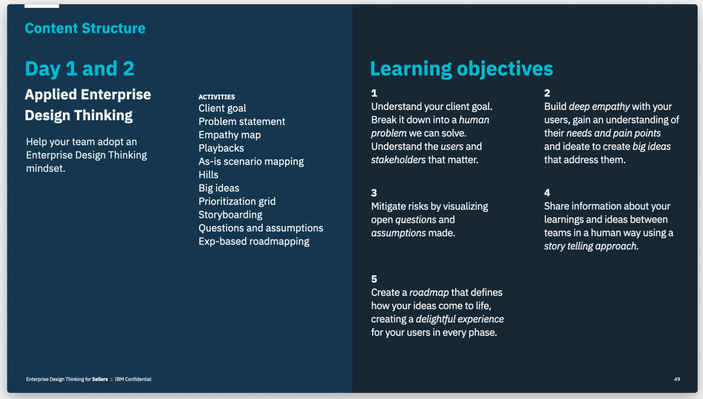
Gaining stakeholder buy-in

Securing the managing director's sponsorship was critical to the program's success, so we tailored our message to resonate.

The program's second phase was a three-day activation workshop

The first two days taught and practiced design thinking through a real client goal.

The third day focused on adoption. Teams mapped their pain points, identified a key behavior goal, and created a habit and coaching plan to integrate design thinking into everyday work.



Content Structure

Day 1 and 2

Applied Enterprise Design Thinking

Help your team adopt an Enterprise Design Thinking mindset.

ACTIVITIES
Client goal
Problem statement
Empathy map
Playbacks
As-is scenario mapping
Hills
Big ideas
Prioritization grid
Storyboarding
Questions and assumptions
Exp-based roadmapping

Learning objectives

1 Understand your client goal. Break it down into a *human problem* we can solve. Understand the *users* and *stakeholders* that matter.

2 Build *deep empathy* with your users, gain an understanding of their *needs and pain points* and ideate to create *big ideas* that address them.

3 Mitigate risks by visualizing open *questions* and *assumptions* made.

4 Share information about your learnings and ideas between teams in a human way using a *story telling approach*.

5 Create a *roadmap* that defines how your ideas come to life, creating a *delightful experience* for your users in every phase.

Applied design thinking education

Even in sales, design thinking's ability to visualize and democratize perspectives helped teams align and consider new ideas.

Content Structure

Day 3

Proficiency

Improve your ability to use and lead activities.

ACTIVITIES
Talking about design thinking
Reinvent the sales cycle

Leading adoption

Help your team adopt an Enterprise Design Thinking mindset.

ACTIVITIES
Your team and design thinking
Adoption tactics

Planning and action

Take action to move your initiatives forward.

ACTIVITIES
Safeguarding against failure
Coaching plan

Learning objectives

1 Talk with your clients and colleagues about the *value* of design thinking.

2 *Re-think your sales process* by matching EDT activities and techniques to your biggest paint points.

3 Assess your team's *EDT capabilities* and skills and identify a path for development.

4 Select specific tactics for encouraging habit and *behavior change* in your team.

5 Envision how your Javelin engagement might fail. Then design the actions that *ensure its success*.

6 Define a plan together with your coach: What do you want to do next to reach your client goal and to grow the design thinking mindset in your team.

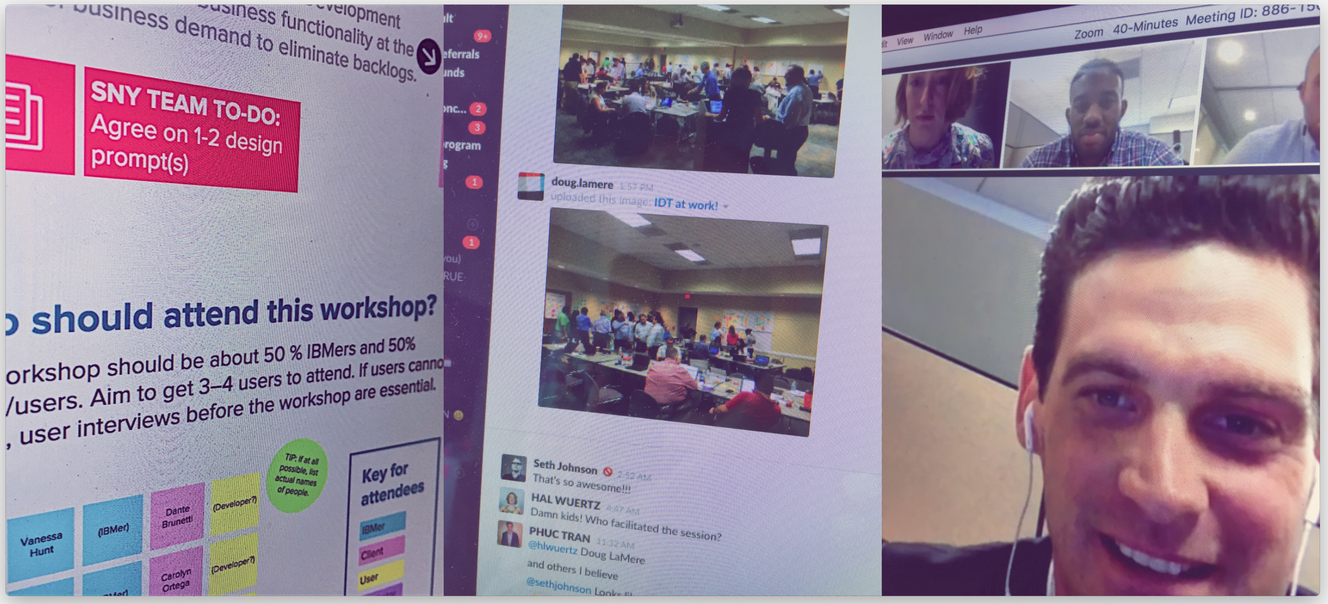
Designing behavior change

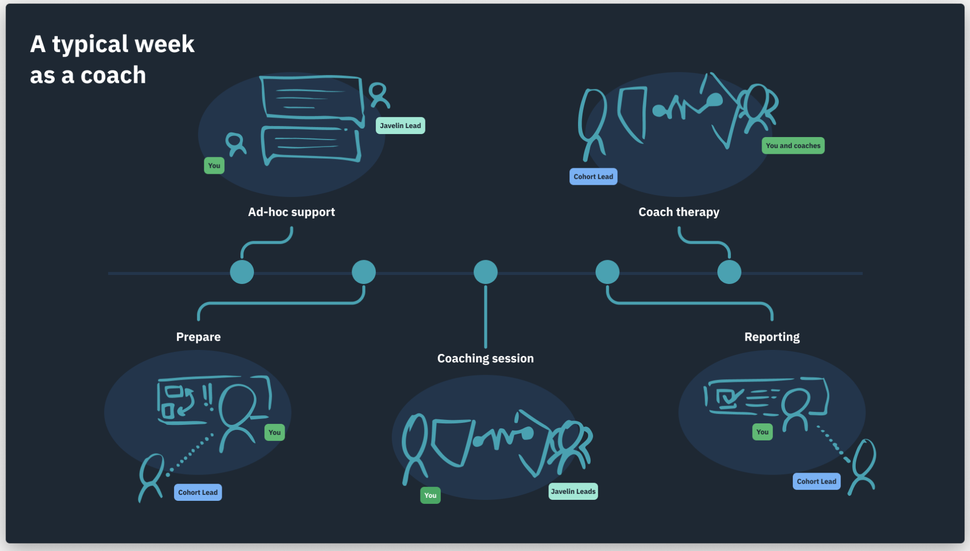
Sales teams left the workshop with achievable ways to change their behavior, tools, and work environment.

The program's third phase was remote coaching

After the workshop, ownership shifted to the coach, with our team providing support. Coaches held weekly remote sessions for eight weeks, guiding the team through their coaching plan and tracking progress toward their target behaviors.

Coaches also had a peer network, which included our team, for troubleshooting and support.





Providing coaching structure

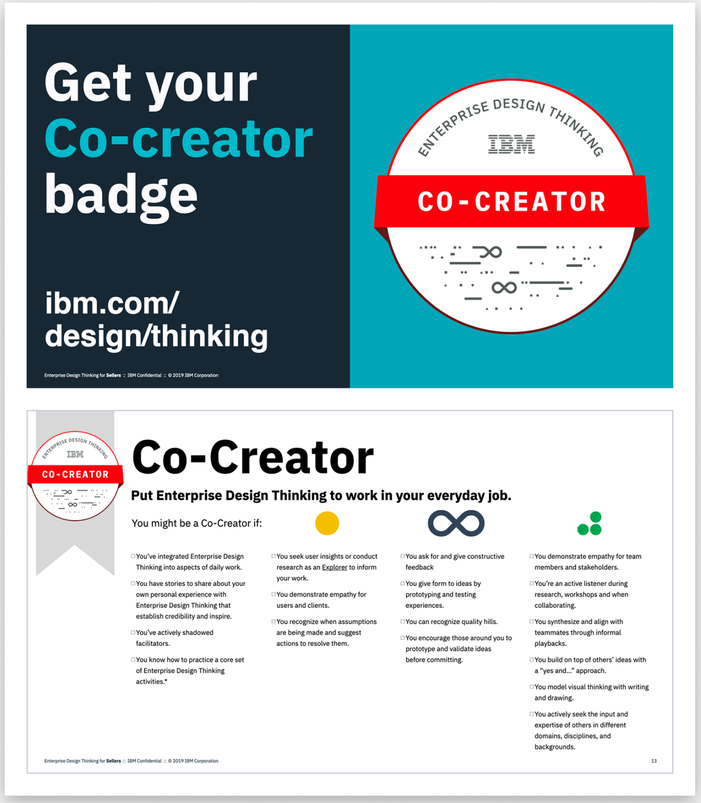
Coaches owned their approach to design thinking adoption, but we provided structure to keep them moving.

New remote ways of working

Tools like Mural enabled remote collaboration at scale and showed design thinking could happen anywhere, which was novel in 2018.

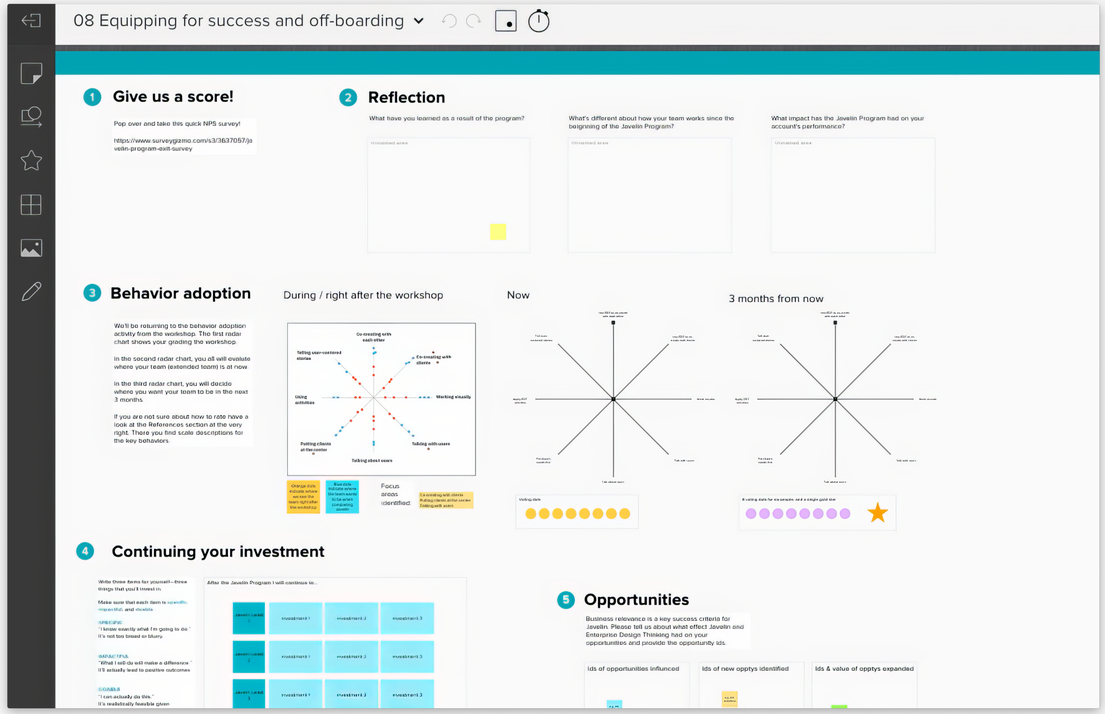
The program's final phase was equipping for success

In the final coaching session, our team led a reflection with the account team. Participants reviewed their progress and set a new behavior change goal they would continue on their own.



Credentialed in design thinking

At the end of the program, participants were eligible for a Co-Creator badge, a significant milestone recognizing their design thinking abilities.

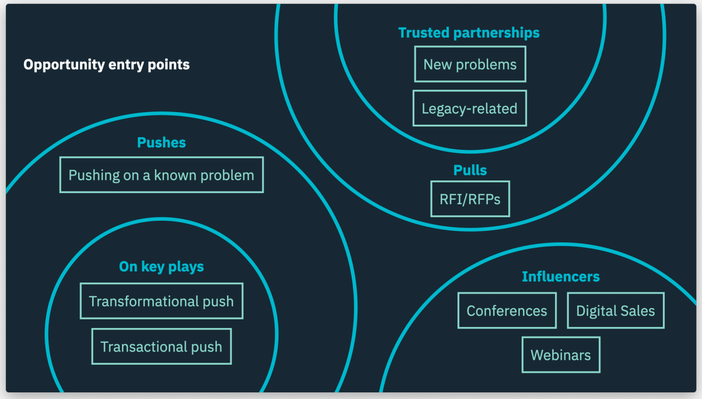


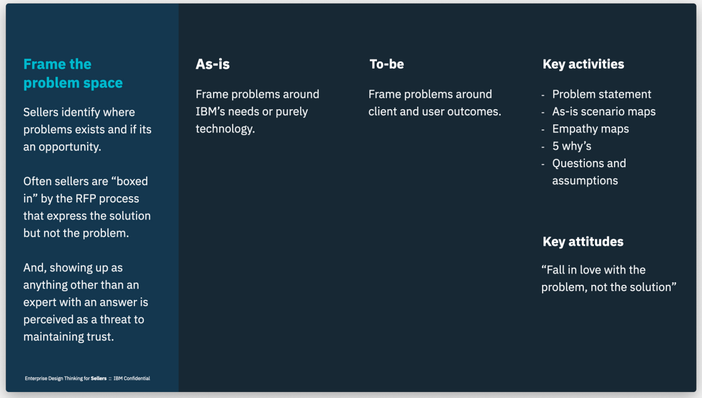
Reflection and new goal setting

This template guided off boarding, supporting reflection, gathering feedback, and setting new goals.

A design decision we made was to close the distance between learning and use
Before the Javelin Program, design thinking training was designer-oriented and taught through simulated problems disconnected from sellers' daily work.

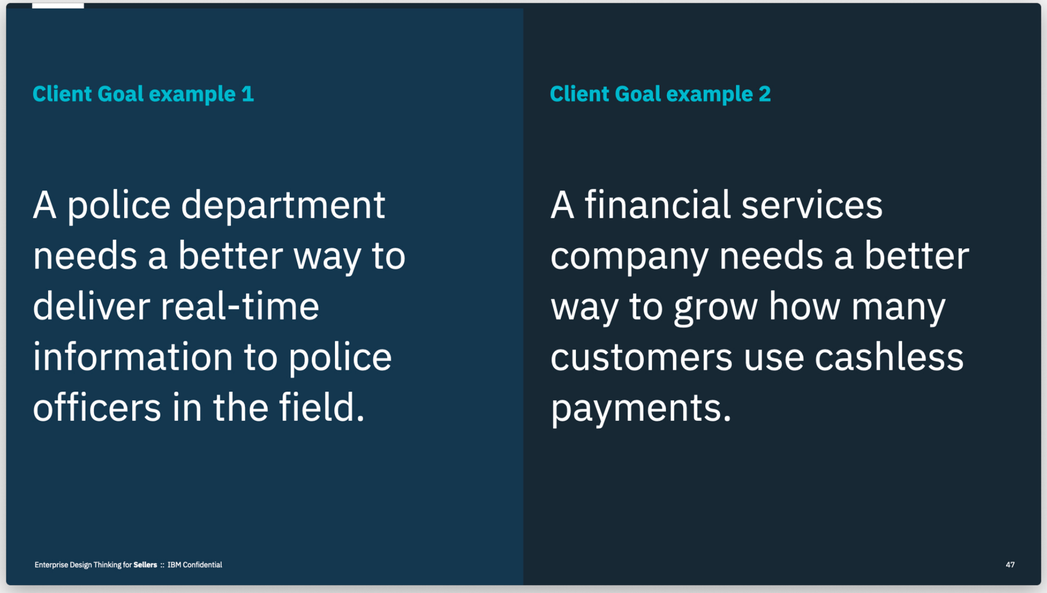
We designed the program to close the gap between learning and use. Each team worked on a real client goal, and we translated the content into seller language and sales activities.





Fitting design thinking to sales
Our understanding of seller workflows let us tailor design thinking activities and mindsets to their daily work.

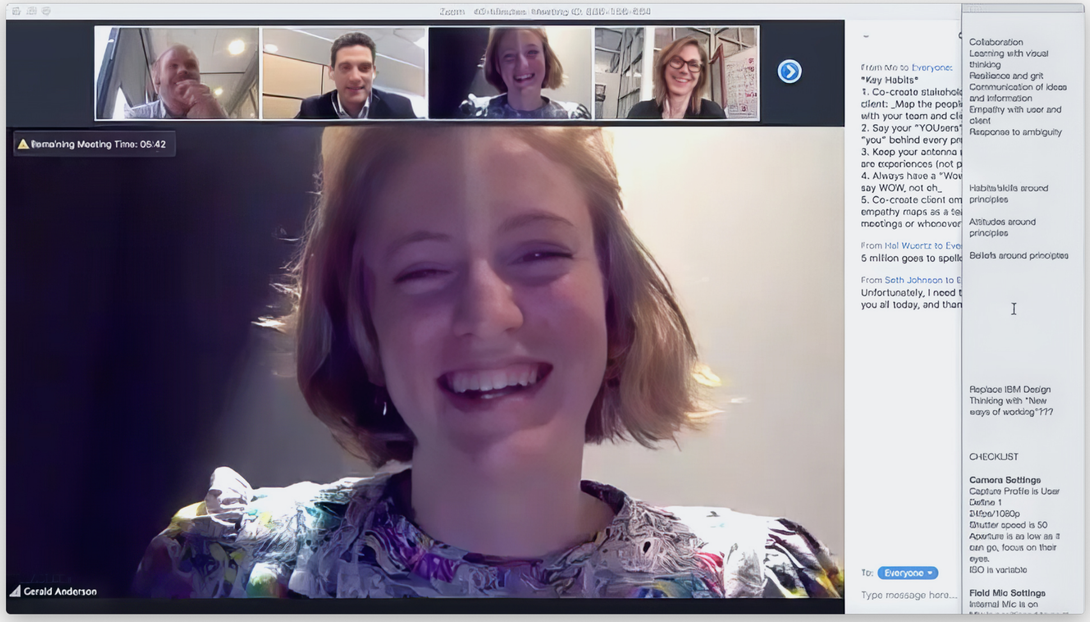
The Client Goal made it real
It was identified during onboarding, explored in the workshop, and advanced through remote coaching.



A design decision we made was to set a big goal and break it into effortless steps

Corporate behavior-change programs are often delivered as a one-time training, with reflection treated as optional. Adoption fails not because participants reject the material, but because performing the behavior inside real work is difficult.

We designed for ability, or making the behavior easier to do. We introduced three supports: weekly coaching, a team-selected behavior goal, and habits embedded into ongoing work.



Coaches made heavy work lighter

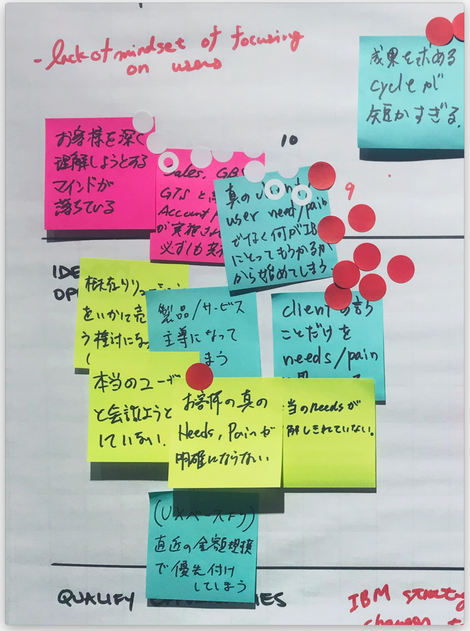
Coaches created a zone of proximal development by removing barriers and modeling the behaviors in practice.

Prioritizing and tracking

Focusing on one key behavior set a clear priority and prevented overwhelm, while tracking improved adoption through self-regulation.

Finding the cues for action

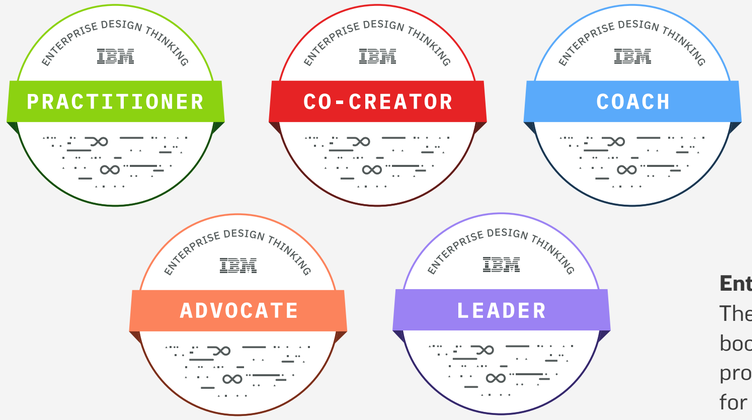
Every habit needs a prompt. We helped sellers identify the right moments, clarifying when to act, not just what to do.



A design decision we made was to scale by using existing organizational supports
Applied learning and reducing barriers to adoption were non-negotiable, yet the program needed to scale to ~80 accounts worldwide within three business quarters.

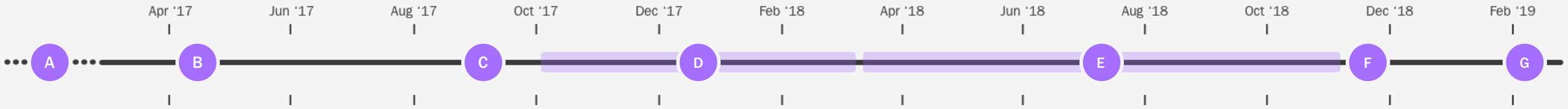
We scaled the program with regional cohort leaders with local market and cultural knowledge, and by building it around existing capabilities: a coaching network, a badging platform, and modern collaboration tools.

Teamwork makes the dream work
A global coaching network and cohort leaders embedded within each region were the backbone of our program.



Enterprise Design Thinking badges
The badging platform bootstrapped sellers during the program and provided a pathway for growth after the program.

Javelin Program timeline
18 months, 2017–2018



(A) Pilot program designed
The team designed the pilot program before I joined.

(B) Pilot accounts activated
I joined during activation of four pilot sales accounts, shadowing the team and conducting research.

(C) Impact playback delivered
I collected data and prepared and presented a playback arguing the quantitative and qualitative impact of the program to IBM's CMO.

(D) Engagement model redesigned
I worked with my team to redesign the engagement model and test it in a second pilot, scaling the program to 80 sales accounts.

(E) Global activation and coaching
I activated 35+ sales accounts, coached coaches, and refined the program.

(F) Program concludes
The program concluded after our global team activated all participating sales accounts.

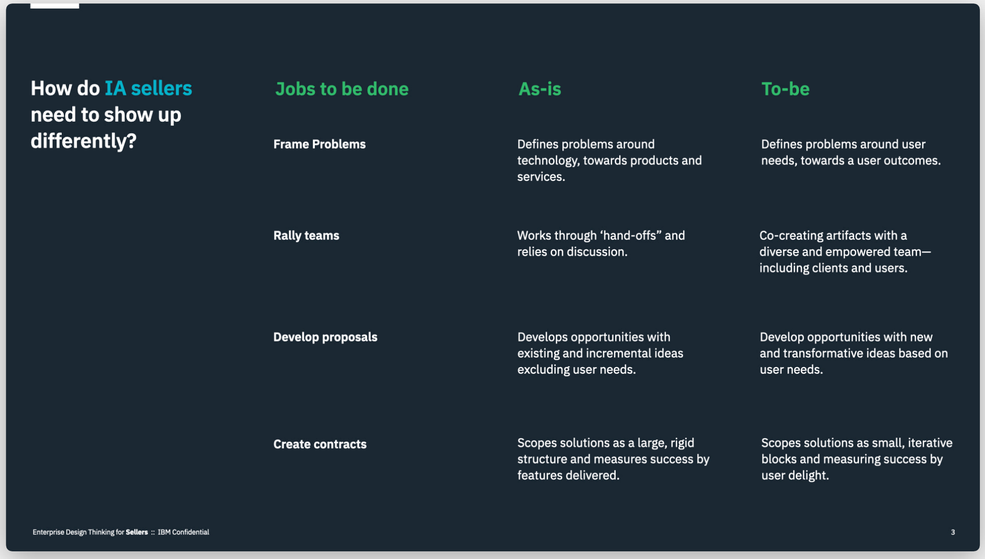
(G) Knowledge shared and scaled
I co-led a workshop to share knowledge and build a community around applying design thinking in sales, and continued sharing my expertise with design teams on engaging sellers.

I formed learning objectives for our scaled program through user research
The initial pilot prioritized workshop facilitation. Sellers found workshops difficult to execute, and the pilot suggested design thinking was more valuable in day-to-day account work.

To understand this, I partnered with a researcher to observe sellers in practice through contextual inquiry, shadowing real client work, interviews, and analysis of the sales cycle.

Through synthesis we identified sellers' jobs-to-be-done, current behaviors, and a target future state. These findings led us to change the direction of the program. Rather than centering on workshops, we embedded small design thinking behaviors into everyday sales activities, forming the foundation of the scaled program.

Crafting learning objectives
These learning objectives became the foundation of the scaled program.



How do IA sellers need to show up differently?	Jobs to be done	As-is	To-be
	Frame Problems	Defines problems around technology, towards products and services.	Defines problems around user needs, towards a user outcomes.
	Rally teams	Works through 'hand-offs" and relies on discussion.	Co-creating artifacts with a diverse and empowered team—including clients and users.
	Develop proposals	Develops opportunities with existing and incremental ideas excluding user needs.	Develop opportunities with new and transformative ideas based on user needs.
	Create contracts	Scopes solutions as a large, rigid structure and measures success by features delivered.	Scopes solutions as small, iterative blocks and measuring success by user delight.

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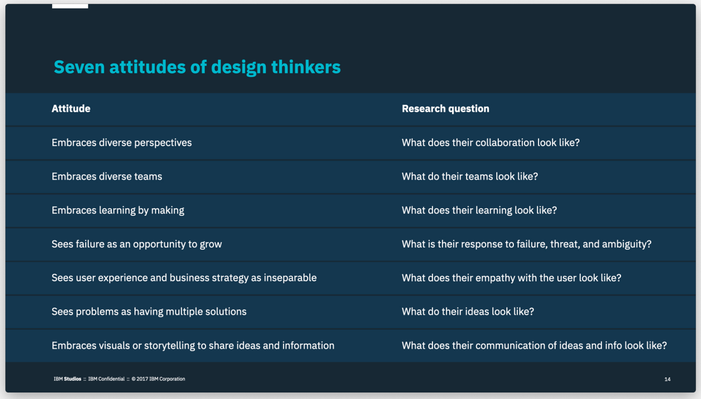

Seven attitudes of design thinkers

Attitude	Research question
Embraces diverse perspectives	What does their collaboration look like?
Embraces diverse teams	What do their teams look like?
Embraces learning by making	What does their learning look like?
Sees failure as an opportunity to grow	What is their response to failure, threat, and ambiguity?
Sees user experience and business strategy as inseparable	What does their empathy with the user look like?
Sees problems as having multiple solutions	What do their ideas look like?
Embraces visuals or storytelling to share ideas and information	What does their communication of ideas and info look like?

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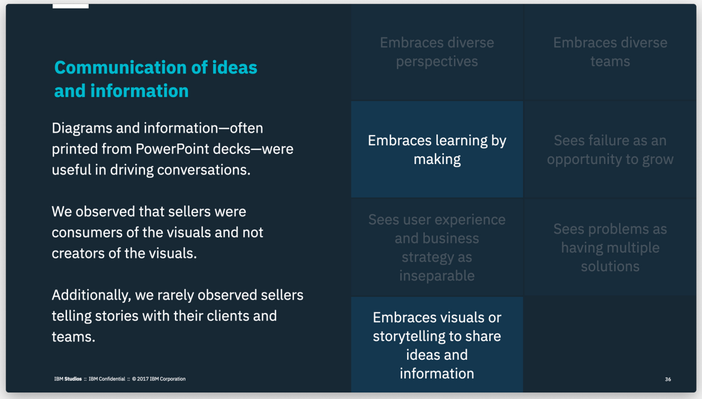


Observation before intervention
Design thinking is a set of behaviors, not activities. We observed how sellers practiced them to establish a baseline and focus our efforts.

I turned the program's impact into a decision leadership could act on

Our program relied on voluntary participation from sales teams and ongoing executive investment. Its value, however, was difficult to evaluate because it produced leading indicators of performance rather than immediate business outcomes like revenue or win rate.

I designed a mixed evidence model to make the program's impact legible to the organization. I paired quantitative performance indicators with qualitative evidence, such as interviews, quotes, and photography, to translate participation into credible business impact.

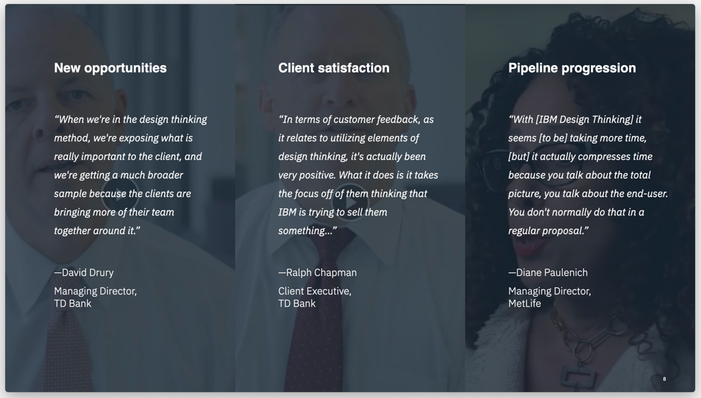
This secured a CMO investment decision and gave managing directors confidence to adopt the program for their teams, allowing it to scale across the organization.

Leading to lagging indicators

I mapped leading and lagging indicators and showed how the program influenced each, creating a holistic view of results.

Stories in the metrics

Through coaching and interviews, I gathered quotes evidencing impact on key metrics.



Showing the story

Mostly with my phone camera, I captured our program's story so it felt alive, relevant, and trustworthy.

I shifted the program from delayed application to immediate application

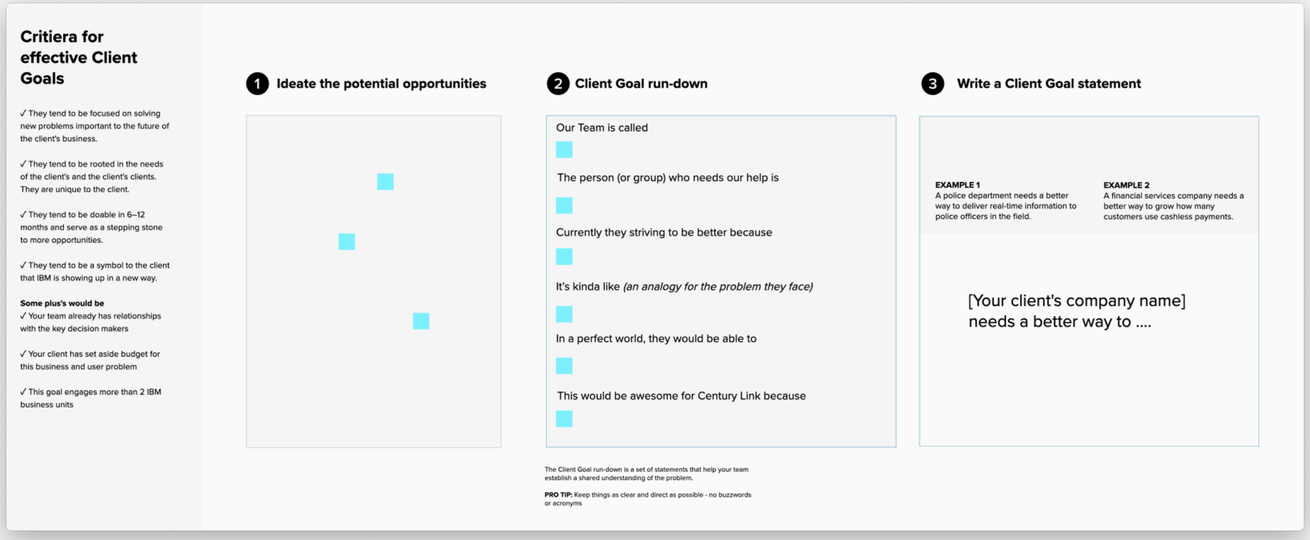
The first pilot showed mixed adoption. Sellers learned the method in isolation and then applied it to a client opportunity during remote coaching. By then some had disengaged, while others struggled to connect it to their work.

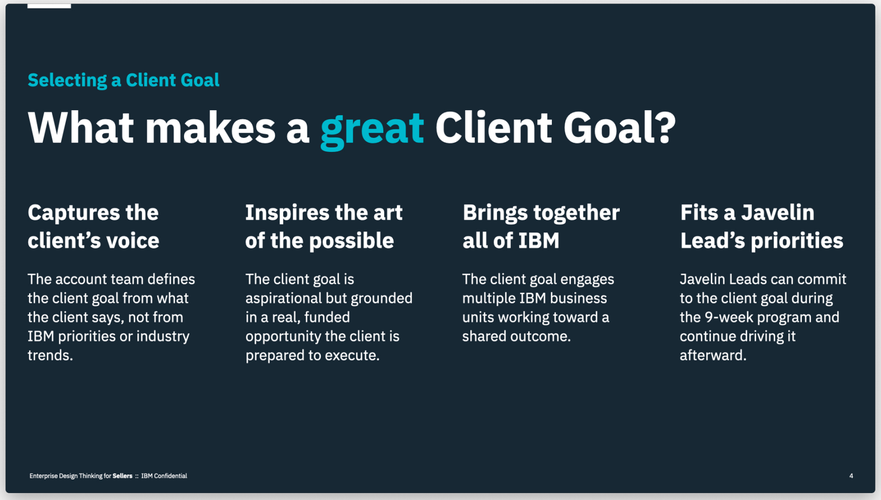
For the scaled program, I proposed applying design thinking to a client opportunity from the start. Making the work relevant helped sellers connect the framework to their responsibilities and increased their confidence to use it.

To support this shift, I designed and embedded a mechanism called the Client Goal into the program. During onboarding, each team defined a business objective tied to their account. This business-oriented problem statement anchored the workshop, adoption plan, and remote coaching.

Forming teams with a Client Goal

This project rundown activity was modified to include the client goal, making the program feel relevant and inspiring participation from busy sellers.





Evolving the Client Goal criteria

This criteria emerged from lessons in the first pilot and was later refined in partnership with our sponsor user.

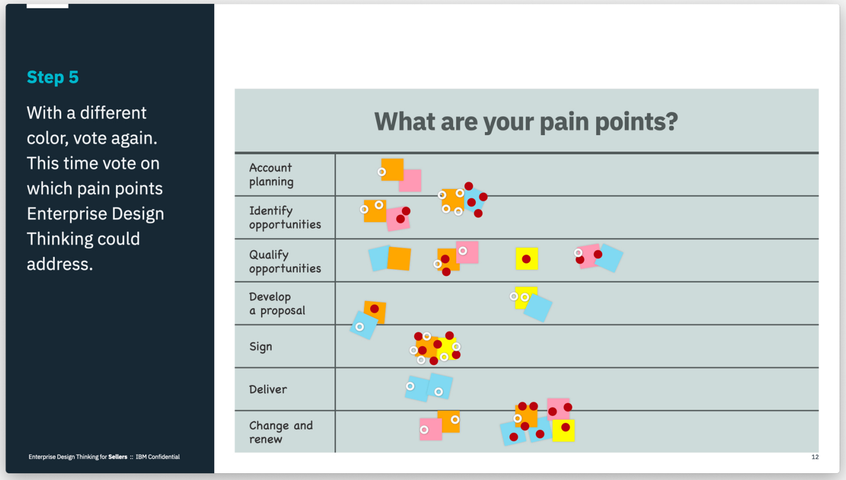
I continuously improved habits until they fit real work and drove adoption

Habits were a core adoption tactic to drive behavior change. After the initial pilot, I designed a habits-based adoption framework, which Sales Enablement scaled across the IBM seller community.

The engagement was positive, but the habits required collaborative activities that were too demanding. I formed a new hypothesis: adoption would improve if habits were tied directly to each team's pain points and required minimal effort.

In the scaled program, I created an activity mapping sales-cycle pain points to design thinking opportunities. This informed a behavior change plan, which included selecting habits to adopt.

Following Fogg's behavior model, we linked habits to team pain points for motivation and designed them to be nearly effortless to do.

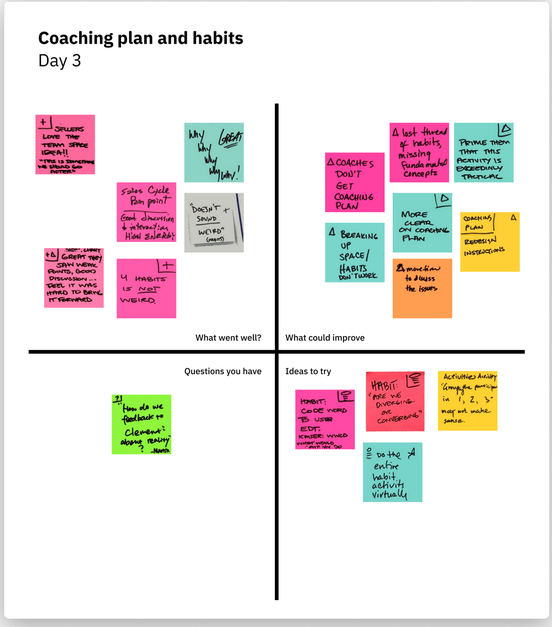


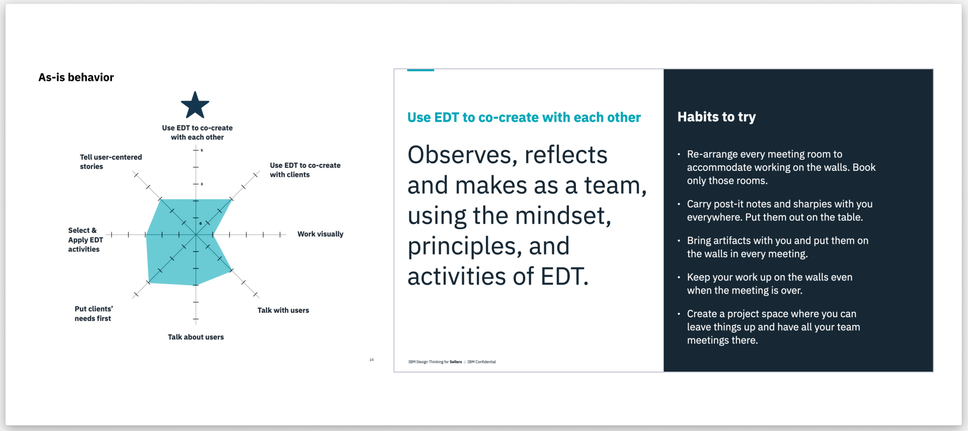
Finding the cues

Mapping pain points to design thinking opportunities revealed habit triggers and clarified a key behavior goal.

Learning in the field

Each cohort functioned as a live test. Feedback grids helped us refine the adoption framework and the starter habits we offered.





Turning goals into actions

The key behavior goal focused the team on the most relevant parts of design thinking, and we paired starter habits to each behavior.

“Graduating from Javelin is not the end of our journey with design thinking, it's rather a new beginning.

For us this is more about culture and methods than about process. It helps us to change the DNA of our team towards client centricity.”

—IBM Managing Director, European car manufacturer

The program grew steadily and won the support of key sales leaders

The Javelin Program began as a small pilot and, over two years, grew into a global education program adopted by IBM’s most critical sales leaders.

We received high levels of engagement and coached hundreds of sellers

Over 90% of IBM’s most prominent sales teams voluntarily engaged in this program as word spread about the content’s value. By the end of 2018, the program engaged nearly 80 account teams and coached several hundred sellers.

We tracked progress several ways, and behavior change was the most important

The program’s success was measured across both quantitative and qualitative outcomes: voluntary enrollment, proficiency (badges), behavior change, new opportunities, pipeline progression, and revenue. Our most valuable in-process metric was a tool we created to measure behavior change.

Teams increased their design thinking maturity by 42% through the program

At the beginning of the program, teams rated their design thinking maturity at 45%. By the end, it had increased to 64% —a 42% relative increase.

We influenced over $1.2B dollars across 233 opportunities from 57 accounts

The financial benefits of using design thinking in client interactions were well documented through this program via measurements in total revenue and pipeline progression.

We gathered personal testimonies demonstrating how the program helped

Individuals who completed the program attributed these changes to improved client relationships and broader, less tech-focused conversations. Design thinking helped sellers adopt a posture of listening, enabling them to respond by addressing root causes.

My message to clients: the right conditions are as important as the right idea.

Upon reflection, empowerment was a critical lever in the program's success

The Javelin Program was one of the most exciting and successful projects of my career. It's where I made an impact on the company and where I could feel the influence on its direction.

Looking back, I've asked myself what made it different. I brought the same curiosity, discipline, and standards I bring to every project, yet the outcome here was unique.

A core principle of Enterprise Design Thinking is diverse and empowered teams. The focus is often on the value of diverse perspectives, but the team's empowerment matters just as much and it was a critical lever in this program's success.

Unstable direction, poor access, and narrow roles disempower teams

I've worked on projects as an individual contributor where my team and I were not empowered, and the contrast was stark. In those situations, I could advocate for better conditions, but I could not commit the organization to them. So work framed as important would lose focus as the next priority emerged, and timelines were set without understanding the work required to do it well. Access to the right people and tools was limited, and design's role defaulted toward delivery rather than shaping direction.

We were expected to deliver results without the conditions needed to achieve them.

Empowerment comes from stability and the agency to act

Empowerment is not an abstract value; it is a set of structural decisions an organization makes to give work a chance to matter. I saw this firsthand in how my leaders created the conditions for success. Our team had a stable priority, sufficient investment, access to the right people, and real decision authority.

Our goal was clear, achievable, and stable

Our leaders, Karel and Nigel, used Hills to make the mission clear and gave us the time we needed. The goal, carefully framed, did not shift once. My team and I were rarely pulled into other priorities. These conditions made ambiguity manageable and allowed us to build expertise.

Our leaders built key relationships and told a compelling story about the program

All of us were enlisted to carefully track our impact and tell a compelling story about our work. With strong relationships and evidence in hand, we were able to secure funding for the global program and persuade sales teams to invest their time over three months.

We were empowered to shadow and interview our users

User research was not a nice-to-have; it was essential to our program. Several times I partnered with another researcher to shadow our users. In addition, Karel and Nigel brought a Sponsor User onto the team. Time spent with him, sometimes entire afternoons, gave me insights about a seller's mindset and a deep understanding of the sales domain. As a result, our content resonated.

We were empowered to restlessly reinvent

Nigel gave us ownership of the Javelin Program and the freedom to decide how to accomplish our goal. When we identified weaknesses, he supported redirecting our efforts to address them. While this required trust on his part and self-direction on ours, it unlocked a passionate creativity we could apply to our biggest problems.